

November: USB Comes Along

The Universal Serial Bus (USB) was introduced. It was intended to offer a single interface for connecting a myriad devices, unlike the existing types of ports (Serial, Parallel, PS/2, etc). Up to 127 devices could be connected to a single USB controller, and devices could be installed and uninstalled without rebooting the PC (such devices/interfaces are called “hot swappable”). Version 1 allowed a maximum data transfer rate of 12 Mbps.

December: Apple Introduces FireWire

The IEEE 1394 standard was adopted. The result of research at Apple Computer, who also gave it the name “FireWire”, the proprietary specification became an industry standard after it was adopted by the IEEE—The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (by document number 1394, which resulted in “IEEE 1394” being used to refer to FireWire). The maximum transfer speeds in the first version was 400 Mbps . It was also used by Sony under the iLink name.

The Internet In India

Before VSNL offered dialup Internet access to the general public, other government bodies were already offering Internet access on a limited scale. ERNET (Education and Research Network), NIC (National Informatics Centre) and STPI (Software Technology Parks of India) were the first ISPs in India. NIC was entrusted with networking different government offices to aid administration. The primary use of the network was exchange of information within the country. NIC offered Internet connections only to these connected offices. STPI was a government body created to encourage and develop export oriented IT firms, and offered all services needed for such firms at a single place. Internet connections were available to only those firms that registered with STPI. VSNL was the first to offered Internet access to the general public. After the Government liberalised the telecommunications policy, private ISPs also allowed to set up shop. The first private ISP was Satyam Infoway, which started operations in Hyderabad in 1998.